

he inherited an administrative quagmire. The legacy includes a long list of grandiose "flagship" projects announced by the CM's predecessors—his BJP senior Vasundhara Raje and the Congress's Ashok Gehlot, who alternately helmed the previous five state governments. Marketed as transformative, these initiatives were often timed to electoral cycles and plagued by shifting priorities, bureaucratic inertia and inadequate follow-through. Some of these projects remain unused; others were abandoned midway or are reeling under cost overruns. What unites them is a trail of squandered public funds and shattered public trust.

COLLATERAL DAMAGE

"The damage isn't just economic, it's ecological," says Ajmer-based environmentalist Ashok Malik, who led a campaign against construction on Ana Sagar's banks. "There must be accountability for such reckless decisions, especially in a desert state where water bodies are sacrosanct." In Jaipur, activist Rajendra Tiwari has battled the "commercialisation" of eco-sensitive zones around the Nahargarh sanctuary, following which both the National Green Tribunal (NGT) and the Supreme Court have rapped the local authorities for ruining the Man Sagar Lake in the name of development.

Yet, the malaise runs deeper. Former chief secretary D.B. Gupta, who was involved in several of the stalled projects, attributes the delays to systemic flaws. "New governments squeeze funds and even abandon projects halfway without putting them to test—a sure recipe for failure, even for the best of plans," he says. Sharma acknowledges the rot. "We're trying to retrieve what we can for public good. Our focus is on solutions, not status quo," he tells INDIA TODAY. A close aide says the CM has sought direct support from Prime Minister Narendra Modi on long-stalled mega projects like the Barmer refinery and Ramjal Setu Link Project (the erstwhile Eastern Rajasthan Canal Project), resulting in clarity on finances and timelines. The challenge ahead is not just to salvage stalled projects but to rebuild a culture of accountability. Featured here are eight projects that symbolise this challenge. ■

2. SEVEN WONDERS PARK, AJMER

LAUNCHED: 2022 (Congress)
COST: Rs 81 crore
STATUS: The Supreme Court has ordered demolition

WRECKED WONDERS

Hailed as a tourist draw under Ajmer's Smart City Project, the Seven Wonders Park now faces court-ordered demolition. In March, the SC upheld an NGT verdict calling the construction of world monument replicas in the catchment of the 12th-century Ana Sagar Lake an ecological violation. The park's 'beautification' had gone ahead despite protests from environmentalists and local leaders, including current assembly speaker Vasudev Devnani. "We had opposed the damage to the lake, but the then Congress government and some officials were adamant," he says. A food court and the Statue of Liberty replica have already been torn down. The apex court has extended the deadline to August for clearing the rest. Officials now propose creating two wetlands to spare adjacent parks and works. ■